



Show of faith: Harmanpreet Kaur will continue to lead India at this year's Asian Games in Japan, with the selectors backing the veteran captain despite the team's early exit from the ICC Women's T20 World Cup in England. GETTY IMAGES

their claims in a tournament with little room for error. India enters directly at the quarterfinal stage, alongside Pakistan, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh, meaning one poor game can end the campaign.

Bumrah's inclusion underlines the seriousness with which India is approaching the tournament, which also falls within an important period for its Olympic qualification campaign. Winning in Aichi-Nagoya will not itself secure a place at LA28.

For the men, qualification is tied to the ICC T20I rankings, with the highest-ranked eligible Asian team at the end of 2026 securing the continent's direct berth, subject to the qualification criteria. India will want to maintain its position at the top of the rankings.

The women arrive with a different equation. Unlike the men, they have already secured their place at LA28 as the highest-placed eligible Asian team at the 2026 Women's T20 World Cup. Harmanpreet's side can therefore focus on retaining its title while building towards Los Angeles.

Harmanpreet Kaur's team is the defending champion, with Smriti Mandhana, Shafali Verma, Deepti Sharma, Richa Ghosh and Renuka Singh forming an experienced core alongside emerging players such as G. Kamalini, N. Sree Charani and Kranti Gaud.

With only six teams competing in the Olympic T20 tournament, India will need depth and flexibility rather than a side built around a few familiar names, and Japan will help clarify where the senior players fit in that longer-term picture.



Young turk: Fifteen-year-old sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi will compete for a top-order slot alongside the regular top three of Sanju Samson, Abhishek Sharma and Ishan Kishan. AFP



Indian contingent

Men

Shreyas Iyer (captain), Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson (wicket-keeper), Ishan Kishan (wicket-keeper), Shivam Dube, Tilak Varma (vice-captain), Nitish Kumar Reddy, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Varun Chakaravathy, Ravi Bishnoi, Jasprit Bumrah, Harshit Rana, Arshdeep Singh, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

Women

Harmanpreet Kaur (captain), Smriti Mandhana (vice-captain), Shafali Verma, Deepti Sharma, Richa Ghosh (wicket-keeper), G. Kamalini (wicket-keeper), Bharti Fulmali, N. Sree Charani, Renuka Thakur, Kranti Gaud, Arundhati Reddy, Shreyanka Patil (subject to fitness), Radha Yadav, Nandni Sharma, Pratika Rawal.

Then there is Pakistan. The draw keeps the two teams apart until the medal stage, leaving open the possibility of an India-Pakistan final in either competition.

The squads have also had to navigate concerns over hotel allocation and accommodation arrangements in Japan, an unwelcome complication in a short knockout tournament where recovery and routine matter. It is a reminder that, unlike a conventional bilateral series, India's cricket teams are operating within the wider logistical demands of a multi-sport event.

India will be expected to leave Aichi-Nagoya with both gold medals. Beyond the results, however, the Games mark an important step in India's transition from defending its Asian Games titles to preparing for a return to the Olympic stage.